

Frequencies beyond this range, whether high or low, are felt rather than heard.

Impedance. Simply, match the impedance of the headphones you are planning to buy with the audio equipment you wish to use. This impedance is measured in ohms. Headphones with low and high impedance should never be confused with each other. Low impedance headphones may vary from 75 to 150 ohms and can be plugged in the playback or recording equipments directly. Whereas, headsets with high impedance, which is typically around 600 ohms, are more apt for studio installations. The high impedance models are rugged and are made up of high-resistance coils that have less fear of being burnt-out as compared to the low impedance ones. They require high-driving signals to achieve the same levels of output as that of headphones with low impedance. Headphones with higher impedance do not guarantee great output all the time—for a device like a portable music player, a headset with maximum impedance of 64 ohms is enough.

Wireless feature. Wireless headsets allow users to enjoy music without being connected to the audio source with wire. These can be used in places like gyms, where trailing cables can get in the way. These come with either of the following three technologies—radio, Bluetooth or infra-red.

Headsets with infra-red technology allow users to move in a range of about seven metres and require a clear line of sight between the audio source and the headset. You cannot move around freely even in your house with these headsets on. These are best used for activities inside a room.

Bluetooth technology uses short-range digital radio signals for transmitting sound from the audio source to the headset. Bluetooth headsets offer almost a similar range of coverage as that of infra-red ones but do not require a straight line of sight. You can move around freely from one room to the other.

Some headsets also use radio technology. These headsets use an FM radio signal and offer two or more frequencies

that help in avoiding any kind of interference from other devices.

Since wireless headsets are expensive, make an informed choice before buying them.

Headphones with mic. The headphones are available with or without a mic. If you use headphones mostly with smartphones or calling tablets, a headphone with mic are a good option for you.

Test them before you buy them. All headphones need to pass an ear test! Before buying headphones, try them on to check for sound quality and comfort. Do not forget to check the build quality to ensure they will last long and are truly worth the price.

Some unique headsets

Let us take a look at some quirky headsets ever made.

Zipper headphones. Designed by Ji Woong, these earphones address the



issue of tangled wires. You need to simply unzip them to use them and zip them back for storage once you are done.

Ripple headsets. Also known as 'more humane audio headset', this one can be simply clipped onto the earlobe instead of being suspended over the ear. It adds to the style, along with adding to the experience. It also has the talk function—just flip down the talk function and start talking.

DEOS diamond earphones. DEOS (defining expression of sound) diamond earphones are encrusted with coloured diamonds, and may cost anywhere between \$4500 and \$60,000 for a pair!

Solar-powered headsets. Solar power can be a reliable source of energy for headsets. One hour of sunlight is good enough to power the headsets for over two-and-a-half hours of running time. ●

The author is a senior assistant editor at EYF

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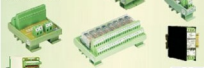
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